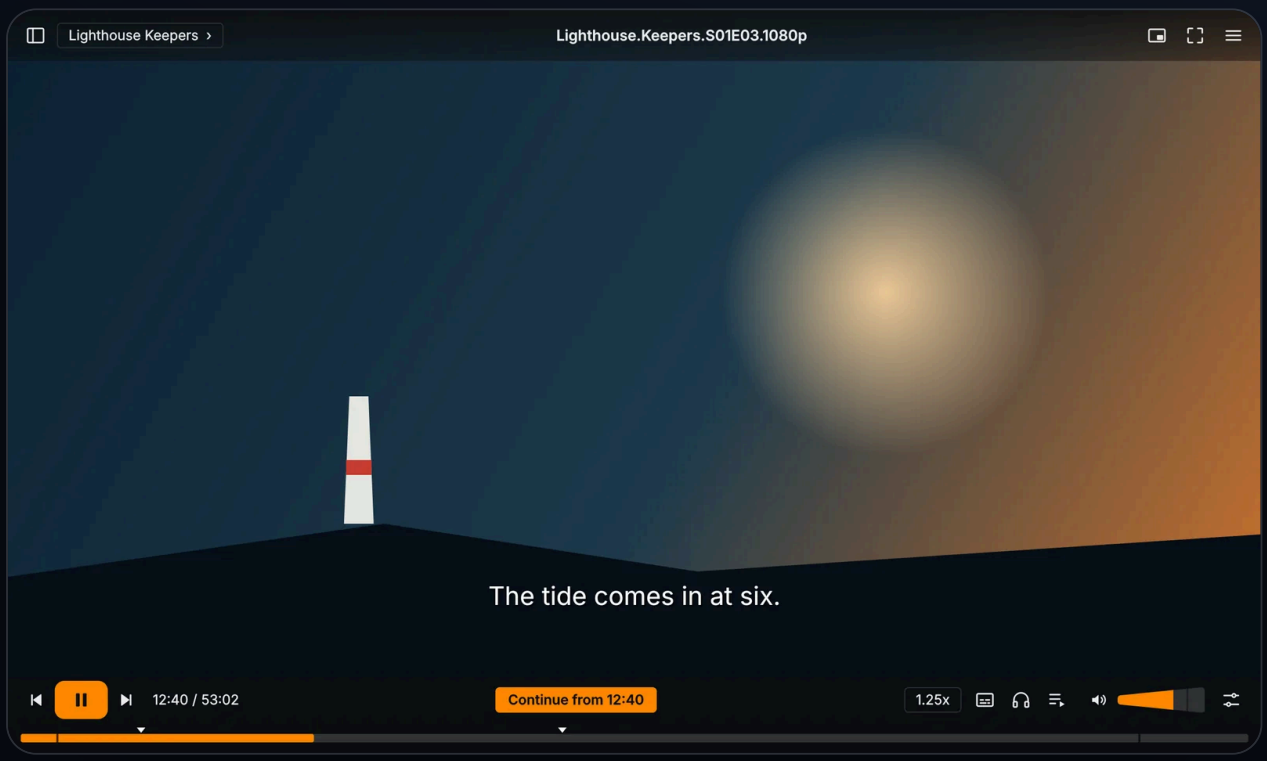
Pylon

User guide

Every screen, panel and setting in Pylon 1.5.0, with pictures and step-by-step how-tos.



Version 1.5.0

nirmaljosephukken.github.io/pylon-player

Contents

Getting started

- Install
- Opening something to watch

The home screen

- Arrange the home screen

The player

- Mouse
- Zoom into the picture
- Picture in picture
- The right-click menu
- Snapshots

The library panel

- Library tab
- Music tab
- Recent tab
- Playlists tab
- Streams tab
- Pin to top

The queue

- Queue mode

The settings panel

- Presets: settings for a show
- Subtitles tab
- Add subtitles to a whole season
- Audio tab
- Video tab
- Playback tab
- Bookmarks tab

Preferences

- General: colours and themes
- Interface
- Playback
- Subtitles
- Controls
- Privacy
- Performance

Keyboard shortcuts

How to...

Your data and updates

Troubleshooting

Getting started

Pylon is a media player that uses VLC's engine to play your files, with a calmer interface and features made for watching shows. It plays everything VLC plays. You install VLC yourself, and Pylon finds it.

Install

Windows 10 and 11

1. Install the 64-bit VLC from videolan.org.
2. Download `Pylon-Setup-1.5.0.exe` from the download page and run it. No admin rights are needed.
3. If Windows says "Windows protected your PC", click **More info**, then **Run anyway**. Pylon isn't code-signed yet.

Linux

1. Install VLC from your distribution's packages, for example `sudo apt install vlc`. The Flatpak and Snap versions of VLC can't be used by other apps.
2. Download `Pylon-1.5.0-x86_64.AppImage` run `chmod +x Pylon-*.AppImage`, then double-click it.
3. The first start adds Pylon to your applications menu and "Open with".

macOS 14 and later (experimental)

1. Install VLC from videolan.org and drag it into Applications.
2. Download `Pylon-1.5.0-macOS.zip`, unzip it and move Pylon to Applications.
3. The first launch is blocked because Pylon isn't signed by Apple. Open **System Settings > Privacy & Security** and click **Open Anyway**.

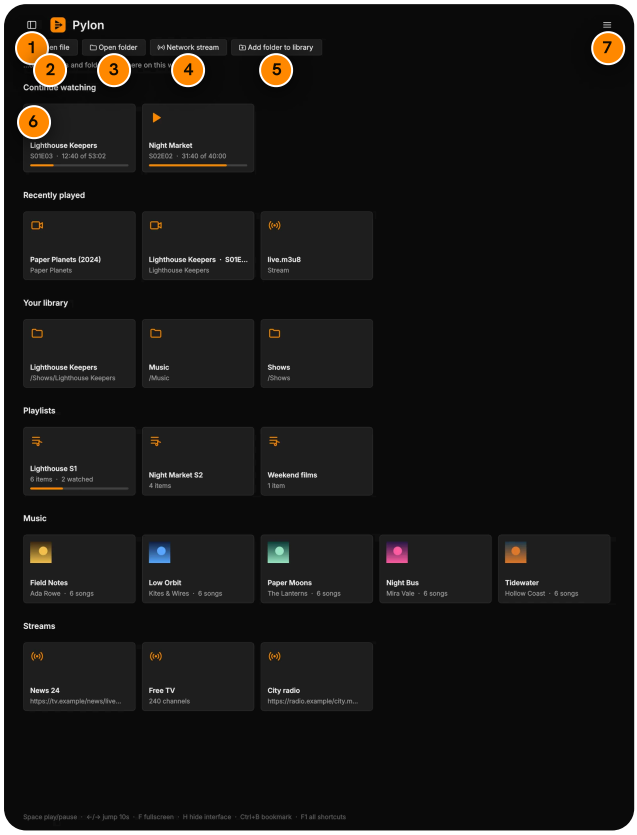
Opening something to watch

- **Drop** files, folders or links anywhere on the Pylon window.
- Use **Open file**, **Open folder** or **Network stream** on the home screen, or the same choices under **Menu > Open**. **Link from clipboard** plays a link or file path you've copied.
- On Windows, right-click a file and choose **Open with > Pylon**. Opening another file while Pylon is running plays it in the same window.
- When you play a file, the rest of its folder goes into the queue in name order, so the next episode is ready.

Make Pylon your default player on Windows. Right-click a video, choose **Open with > Choose another app**, pick Pylon and click **Always**. Or open **Settings > Apps > Default apps**, type a file type such as `.mkv`, and choose Pylon.

The home screen

Pylon opens on the home screen: what you were watching, what you played recently, your library folders, playlists, music and saved streams. Click any card to play it, or right-click it for more choices.



The home screen. Click a number to see what it does.

1. **Library panel** Opens the library panel on the left: your folders, music, recent files, playlists, streams and the queue. Shortcut: Ctrl+L.
2. **Open file** Pick one or more files to play. Shortcut: Ctrl+O.
3. **Open folder** Plays every video or song in a folder, in name order. Shortcut: Ctrl+F.
4. **Network stream** Paste a link to a video, a live stream or a channel list (.m3u). Shortcut: Ctrl+N.
5. **Add folder to library** Adds a folder to Your library, so it appears on the home screen and in the Library and Music tabs.
6. **Continue watching** Everything you started but didn't finish, with how far you got. Click to carry on. Hover a card and click the double tick to mark it as watched.
7. **Menu** Open, Home, Library, Preferences, keyboard shortcuts, updates and About.

Arrange the home screen

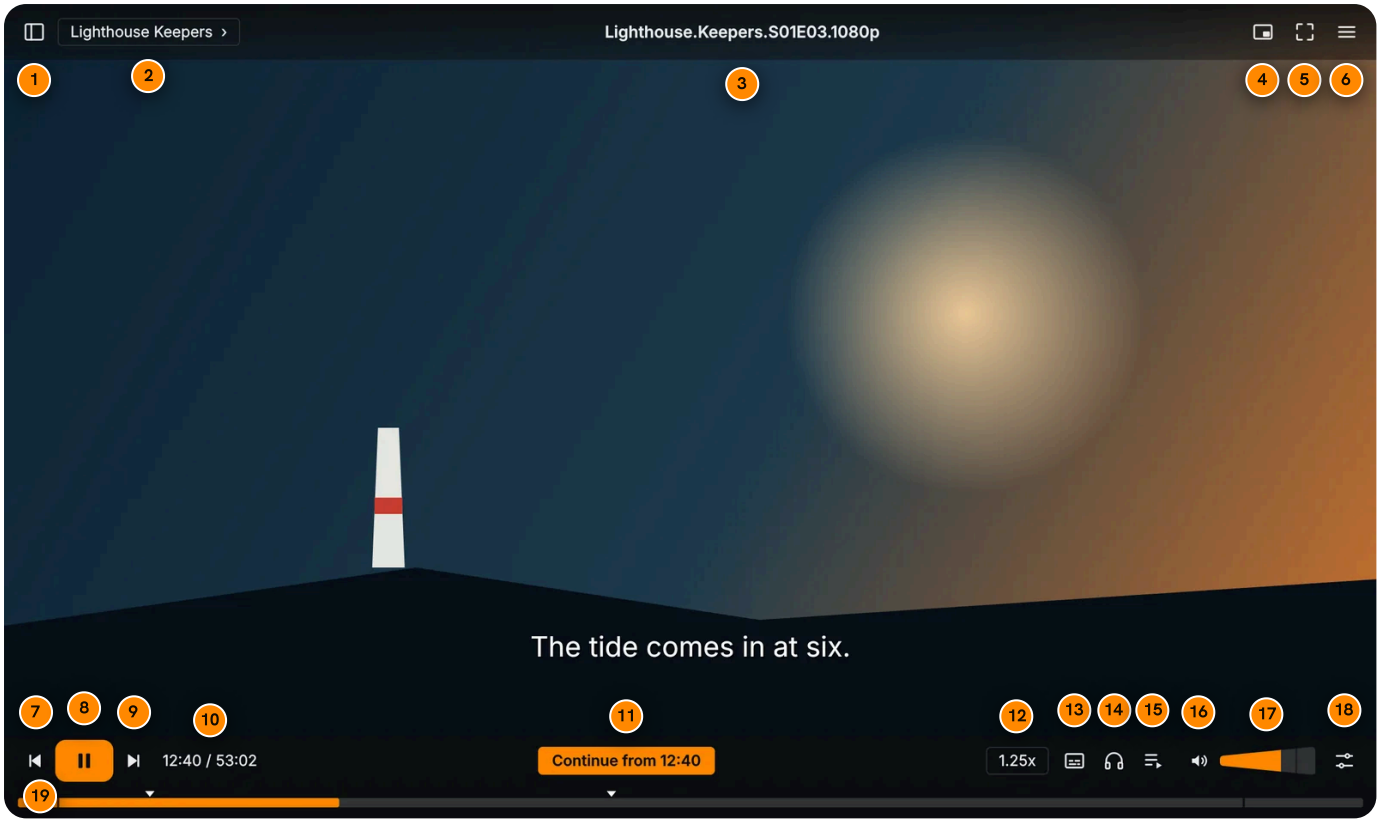
Open **Preferences > Interface** and find **Home screen sections**.

1. Drag a section by its handle (the dots on the left) to move it up or down.
2. Click the eye next to a section to show or hide it. A crossed-out eye means hidden.

Hiding a section doesn't delete anything. The **Music** section shows your albums, pinned ones first, then the newest. Pinned playlists and streams also come first in their sections.

The player

While something plays, the top and bottom bars float over the picture. They appear when you move the mouse and fade away when you stop. Press `H` to hide them completely, or keep them on screen with **Preferences > Interface > Keep the controls visible when not in fullscreen**.



The player with both bars showing.

1. **Library panel** Shows or hides the library panel and queue. Shortcut: Ctrl+L.
2. **Folder name** The folder the file came from. Click it to browse that folder in the library panel without stopping the video.
3. **Title** The name of what's playing. For a stream it also shows what's on, if the stream says.
4. **Picture in picture** A small window that stays on top of other apps. Shortcut: Ctrl+P. Esc goes back.
5. **Fullscreen** Shortcut: F or Enter. Esc leaves fullscreen.
6. **Menu** Open files and links, Home, Library, Add subtitles, Add bookmark, Take a snapshot, Preferences, Keyboard shortcuts, Check for updates and About.
7. **Previous** The previous item in the queue. Shortcut: P.
8. **Play / pause** Shortcut: Space, or click anywhere on the video.
9. **Next** The next item in the queue, or the next file in the folder. Shortcut: N.
10. **Time** Where you are and how long it is. Click to show the time remaining instead.
11. **Continue from** Appears when you open something you didn't finish. Click it to jump back to where you stopped. You can make Pylon always continue, or always start from the beginning, in Preferences > Playback.
12. **Speed** Shows only when the speed isn't 1x. Click it to open the speed settings. Keys: [slower,] faster, = normal.
13. **Subtitles** Choose a subtitle track, add subtitle files, or open the timing and look settings. V switches to the next track.
14. **Audio** Choose an audio track (for example a different language) and where the sound plays: speakers, headphones and so on. B switches to the next track.
15. **Queue** Opens the library panel on the queue. Shortcut: Ctrl+Q.
16. **Mute** Shortcut: M.
17. **Volume** Click, drag or scroll over it. Up and Down change it in steps of 5. It goes to 125%, or to 150% or 200% if you raise the limit in Preferences > Playback.
18. **Settings panel** Subtitle, audio, video and playback settings in a panel on the right, without covering the video. Shortcut: Ctrl+T.
19. **Seek bar** Click or drag to move. Hover to see a preview picture of that moment. Small triangles mark your bookmarks, and thin lines mark chapters.

Mouse

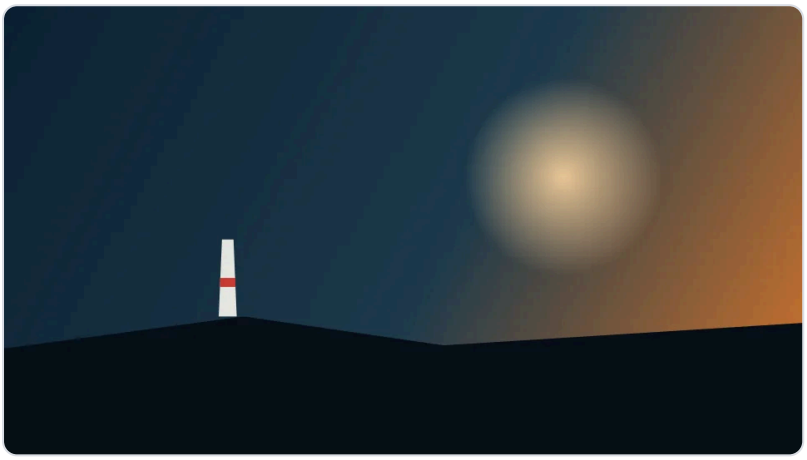
- **Click** the video to play or pause, **double-click** for fullscreen, **scroll** to change the volume and **right-click** for the menu. You can change what each click does in **Preferences > Controls**, including the middle button and the back and forward buttons.

- **Hover the seek bar** to see a preview picture of that moment. Previews are made in the background the first time you play a video, and kept for next time. They work for files on your computer, not online streams.

Zoom into the picture

Hold `Ctrl` and scroll over the video to zoom in on the spot under the mouse, or use `Ctrl`+`=` and `Ctrl`+`-`. While zoomed, drag the picture to look around. `Ctrl`+`0` resets the zoom.

Picture in picture

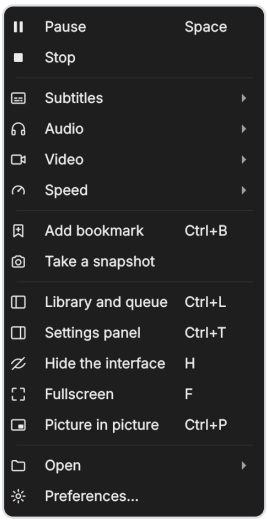


Click the picture-in-picture button in the top bar or press `Ctrl`+`P`. Pylon becomes a small borderless window that stays on top of your other apps.

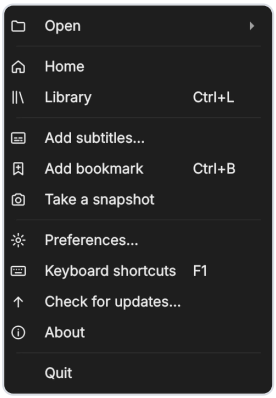
Drag it anywhere, and drag its edges to resize it. Press `Esc` or the button again to go back.

The right-click menu

Right-click the video for the things you change most while watching: subtitle and audio tracks, the video track and aspect ratio, speed, bookmarks, snapshots, the panels, fullscreen and picture in picture.



Right-click menu



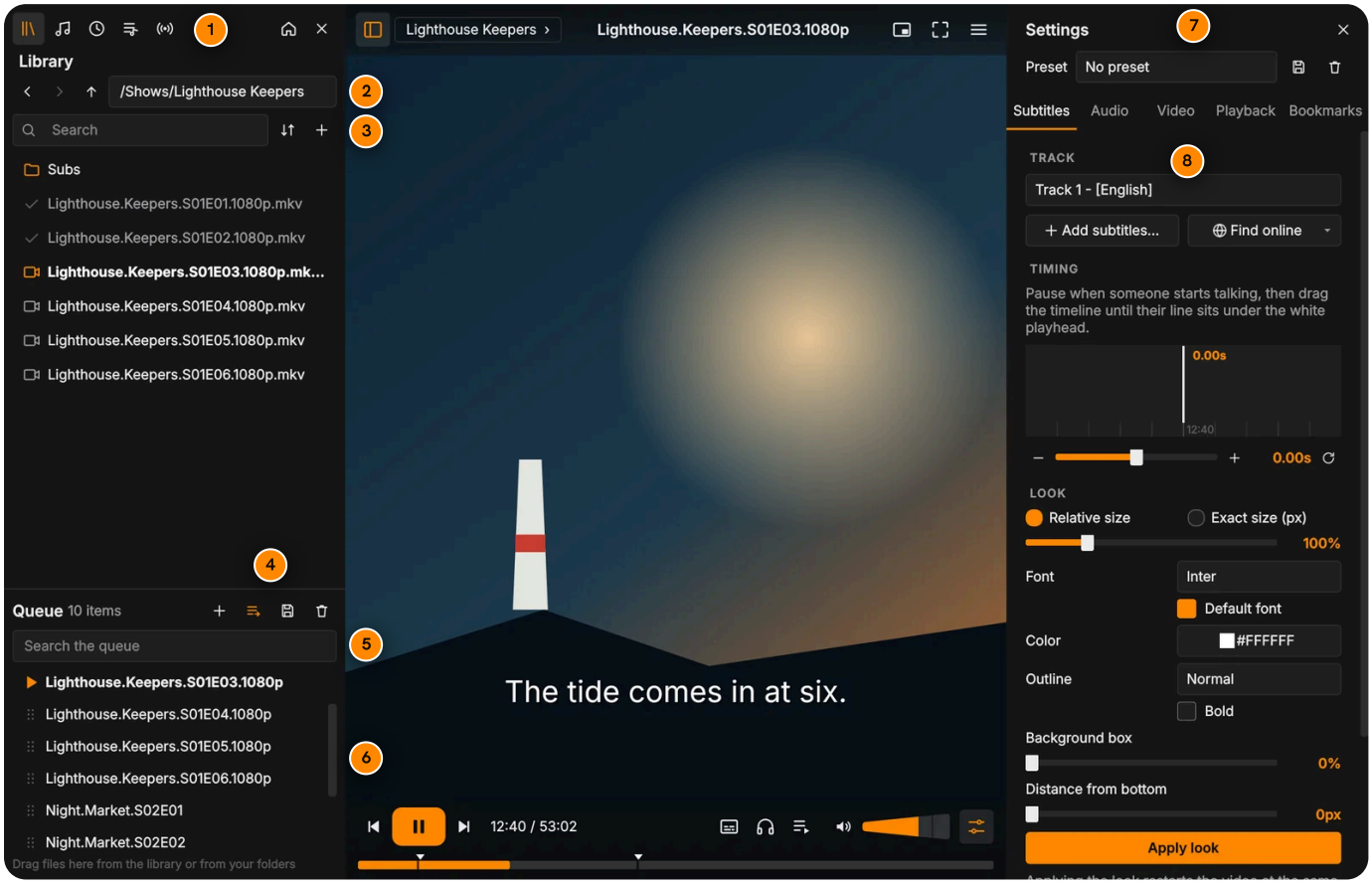
The Menu button

Snapshots

Press `Shift`+`S`, or choose **Take a snapshot** in the menu, to save the current picture. Snapshots go to `Pictures\Pylon`.

The library panel

The library panel opens on the left with `Ctrl`+`L`, the button at the top left, or by clicking the folder name in the top bar. The video keeps playing next to it. The top half has five tabs; the bottom half is the queue.

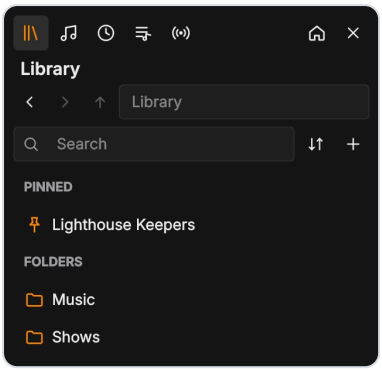


The library panel on the left and the settings panel on the right.

1. **Library tabs** Library (your folders), Music, Recent, Playlists and Streams. Each tab is described below. The house next to them goes back to the home screen, and the cross closes the panel.
2. **Back, forward, up and the address bar** Move between folders you've opened, like a web browser, or go up one folder. The address bar shows where you are: type or paste a folder path and press Enter to go there.
3. **Search, sort and add** Search filters what's shown as you type. Sort offers Name, Date modified (newest), Unwatched first and Watched first. The + button adds a folder to the library or opens a file or folder.
4. **Queue buttons** From left: add files to the queue; the queue mode (Stop, Shuffle, In order or Loop, see The queue below); save the queue as a playlist, or as a channel list if it's all streams; and clear the queue. Clearing never touches your files.
5. **Search the queue** Appears when the queue has more than 8 items. Type to find an item, handy for long channel lists.
6. **The queue** Double-click an item to play it. Drag to reorder, and drag files in from the library or your file manager.
7. **Presets** Saved settings for a show: subtitle timing and look, tracks, speed and picture. The save button stores the current settings for every file in this folder; the bin deletes the preset.
8. **Settings tabs** Subtitles, Audio, Video, Playback and Bookmarks. Each tab is described below.

`Ctrl`+`Shift`+`L` shows or hides both side panels at once. Preferences > Interface lets you choose which tab each panel opens on.

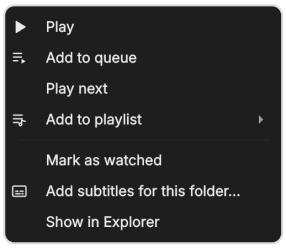
Library tab



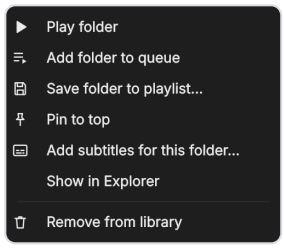
Library tab

Your library folders, with pinned folders at the top. Double-click a folder to open it, and a file to play it with the rest of its folder queued.

- Use the **+** button, or **Add folder to library** on the home screen, to add a folder.
- Files you've watched have a tick. Sort by **Unwatched first** to see what's next.
- Select several files with `Ctrl` or `Shift`, and drag them into the queue.
- Right-click a file or folder for more:

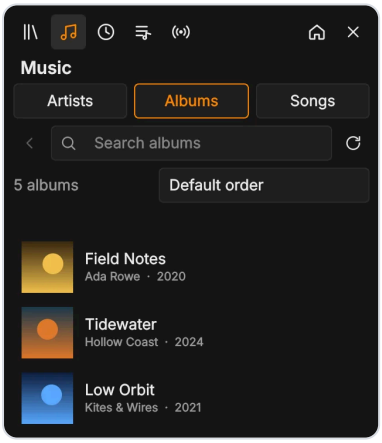


Right-click a file



Right-click a folder

Music tab

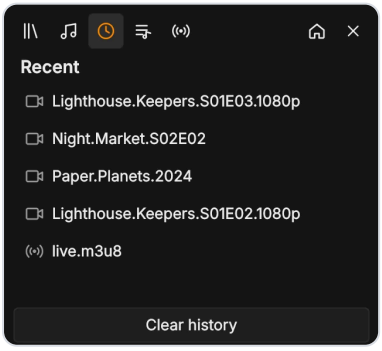


Music tab

Songs from your library folders, with cover art from the files. Switch between **Artists**, **Albums** and **Songs**. Open an album and press **Play**, or double-click any song.

Pylon reads your music in the background. Click the circular arrow to look for new music. Right-click an artist or album to play it, queue it, add it to a playlist or **Pin to top**.

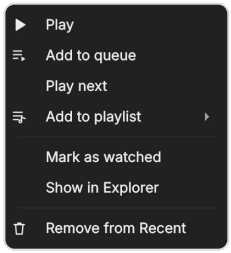
Recent tab



Recent tab

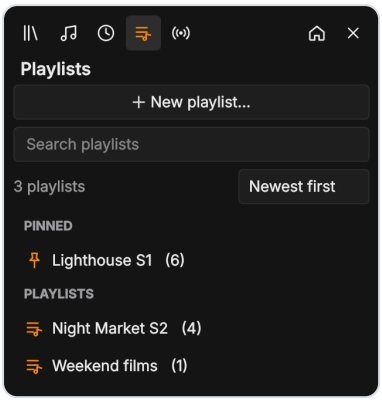
Everything you played recently, newest first. Right-click an item to play it, queue it, add it to a playlist or mark it as watched. Streams also have **Copy link** and **Save to Streams**.

Remove from Recent takes one item (or several selected items) off the list, along with where you stopped. **Clear history** at the bottom forgets everything.



Right-click in Recent

Playlists tab

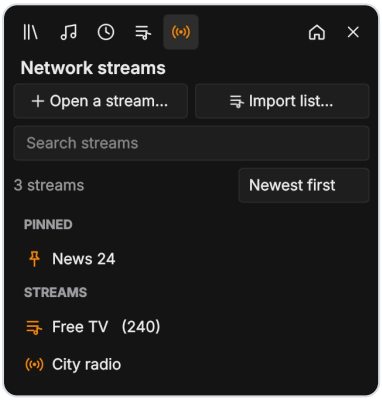


Playlists tab

Click **New playlist…** to make one, or right-click files, folders, albums or the queue and choose **Add to playlist**. The number next to each name is how many items it has.

Playing a playlist continues from the first item you haven't finished. Right-click a playlist to play it, queue it, add files, rename it, export it as an `.m3u` file, pin it to the top or delete it. Deleting a playlist never deletes your files.

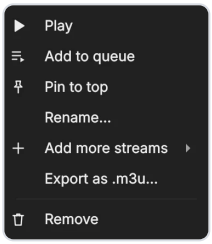
Streams tab



Streams tab

Saved streams and channel lists. **Open a stream…** plays a link and can save it here. **Import list…** saves an `.m3u` channel list, and its channel count appears next to the name. You can also drop `.m3u` files straight onto this list.

Double-click a channel list to load its channels into the queue, where you can search them. Right-click it to add more streams, rename it, export it or remove it.

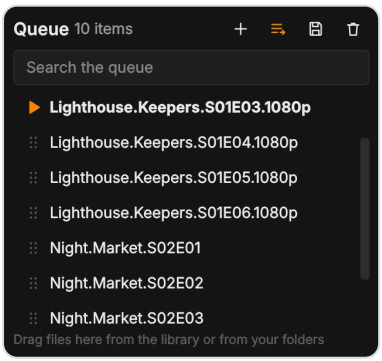


Right-click a channel list

Pin to top

Right-click a library folder, stream, playlist, artist or album and choose **Pin to top**. Pinned items sit in their own group at the top of the tab whatever the sort order, and come first on the home screen. Choose **Unpin** to put an item back.

The queue



The queue

The queue is the list of what plays next, at the bottom of the library panel. Open it with `Ctrl` + `Q` or the queue button on the bottom bar.

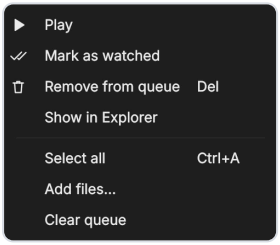
- Double-click an item to play it. Drag items to reorder them.
- Drag files in from the library or from your file manager, or right-click a file anywhere and choose **Add to queue** or **Play next**.
- Select several items with `Ctrl` or `Shift`, then right-click to mark them watched or remove them, or press `Delete`.
- With more than 8 items, a search box appears above the queue.

Queue mode

The button above the queue decides what happens when an item ends. Click it to cycle through the modes:

MODE	WHAT HAPPENS WHEN AN ITEM ENDS
Stop (grey button)	Playback stops.
Shuffle	The queue is mixed up (what's playing stays first) and plays in that order. Leaving Shuffle puts the original order back.
In order	The next item in the queue plays. This is the default.
Loop	The same item plays again.

The same choice is in the settings panel under **Playback**, along with **Start the queue again when it reaches the end**, which repeats the whole queue, and works with Shuffle too. **Preferences > Playback** sets the mode Pylon starts in.



Right-click in the queue

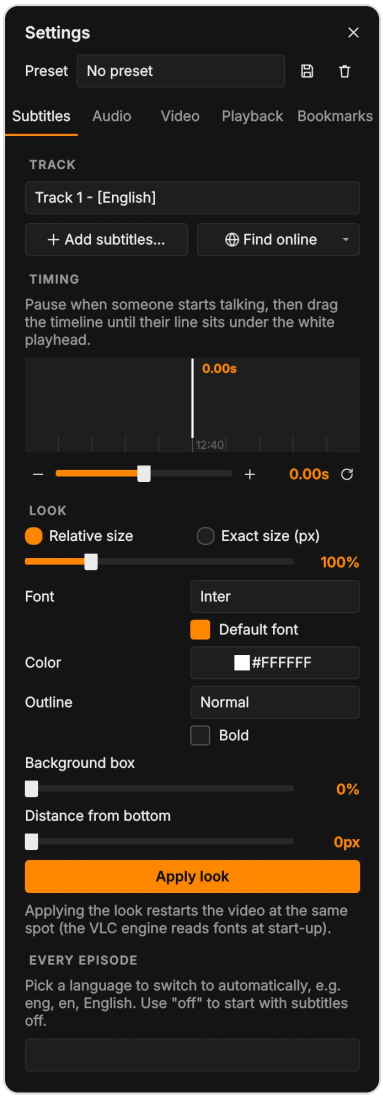
The settings panel

Press `Ctrl` + `T` or click the sliders button at the bottom right. The panel opens on the right, so you can adjust things while the video plays.

Presets: settings for a show

A preset keeps subtitle timing and look, audio and subtitle tracks, speed and picture settings for a show. Set things up once, then click the save button next to **Preset** and give it a name. Every file in that folder uses it automatically from then on. Pick another preset from the list, or **No preset**, at any time.

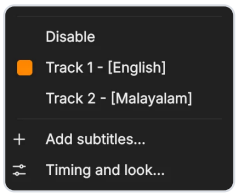
Subtitles tab



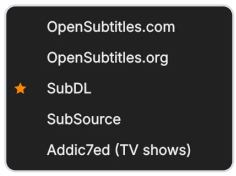
Subtitles tab

- **Track**: choose a subtitle track. **Add subtitles…** adds files; **Find online** opens a subtitle site in your browser.
- **Timing**: pause when someone starts talking, then drag the timeline until their line sits under the white playhead. The - and + buttons, the slider, and the `G` and `J` keys move subtitles 50 ms at a time.
- **Look**: size (relative or exact pixels), font, color, outline, bold, background box and distance from the bottom. Click **Apply look**. The video restarts at the same spot, because VLC reads these when it starts.
- **Every episode**: a language to switch to automatically, such as `eng` or `English`. Use `off` to start with subtitles off.

Pylon also finds subtitle files next to the video, or in a `Subs` or `Subtitles` folder, by itself. How closely names must match is set in **Preferences > Subtitles**.

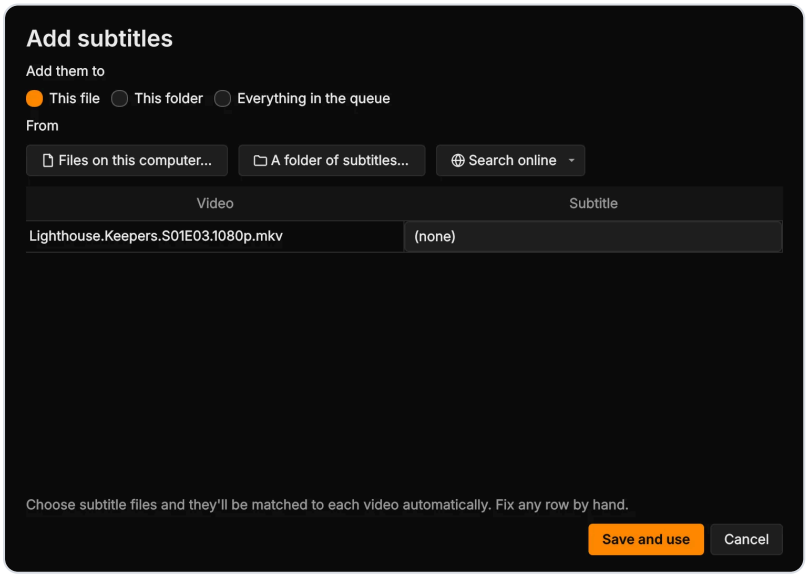


Subtitles button

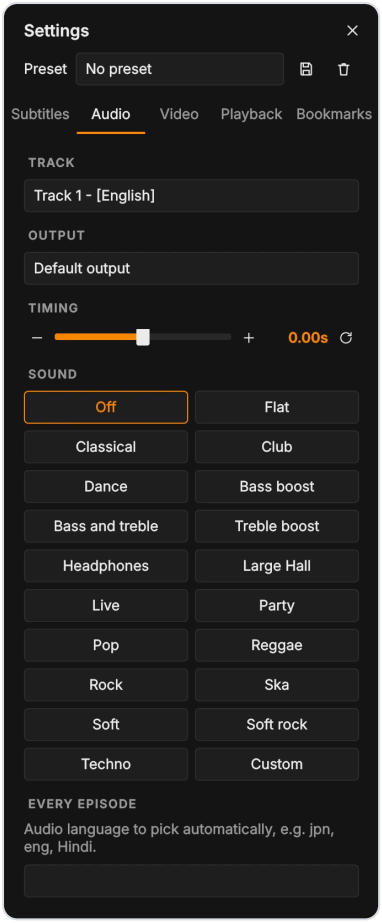


Find online, with a preferred site starred

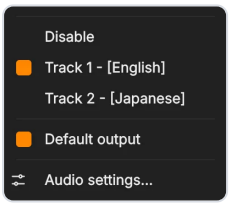
Add subtitles to a whole season



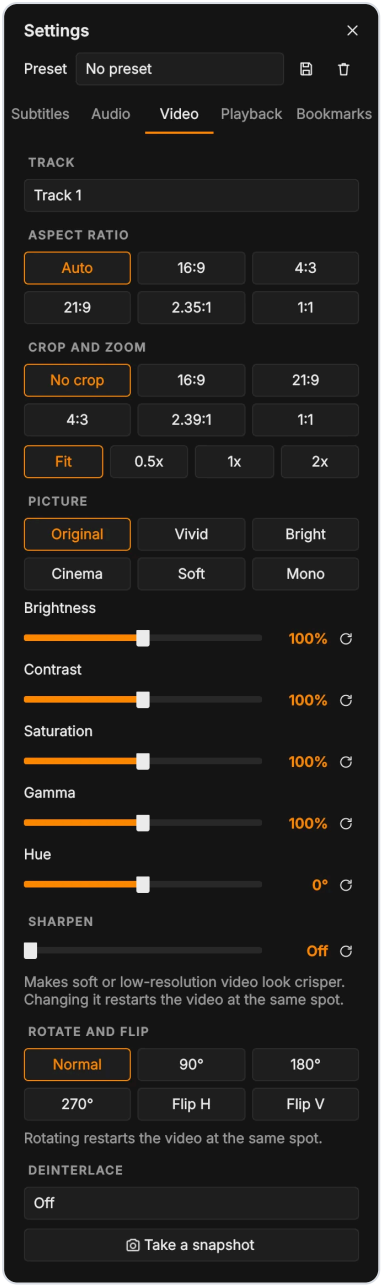
1. Choose **Add subtitles…** in the Subtitles tab, the subtitles button or the menu.
2. Pick where they go: **This file**, **This folder** or **Everything in the queue**.
3. Choose **Files on this computer…** or **A folder of subtitles…**. Each subtitle file is matched to its video by name or episode number (S01E02, 1x02, E02).
4. Fix any row by hand, then click **Save and use**. Pylon remembers the pairings.



Audio tab



Audio button



Video tab

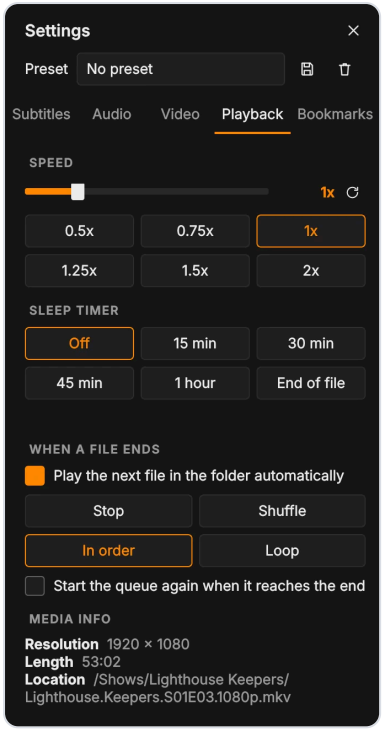
Audio tab

- **Track** and **Output**: the audio track, and where sound plays (speakers, headphones and so on).
- **Timing**: move the sound earlier or later if it doesn't match the picture. Keys: `K` later, `Shift`+`K` earlier.
- **Sound**: VLC's equalizer presets in one click. Hover a preset to see what it does. **Custom** opens a 10-band equalizer; double-click any slider to reset it to 0 dB, or click **Flat** to reset them all.
- **Every episode**: an audio language to pick automatically, such as `jpn` or `eng`.

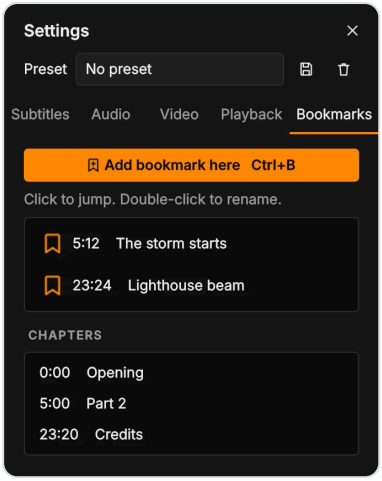
Video tab

- **Aspect ratio**, **Crop and zoom**: fix a stretched picture or remove black bars.
- **Picture**: one-click looks (Original, Vivid, Bright, Cinema, Soft, Mono) and sliders for brightness, contrast, saturation, gamma and hue. Each slider's circular arrow resets it.
- **Sharpen**: makes soft or low-resolution video look crisper.
- **Rotate and flip**, and **Deinterlace** for old TV recordings with comb-like lines.

Changing sharpen or rotation restarts the video at the same spot.



Playback tab



Bookmarks tab

Playback tab

- **Speed**: from 0.5x to 2x.
- **Sleep timer**: stop after 15, 30 or 45 minutes, an hour, or at the end of this file.
- **When a file ends**: play the next file in the folder, the queue mode, and whether the queue starts again at the end.
- **Media info**: resolution, length and where the file is.

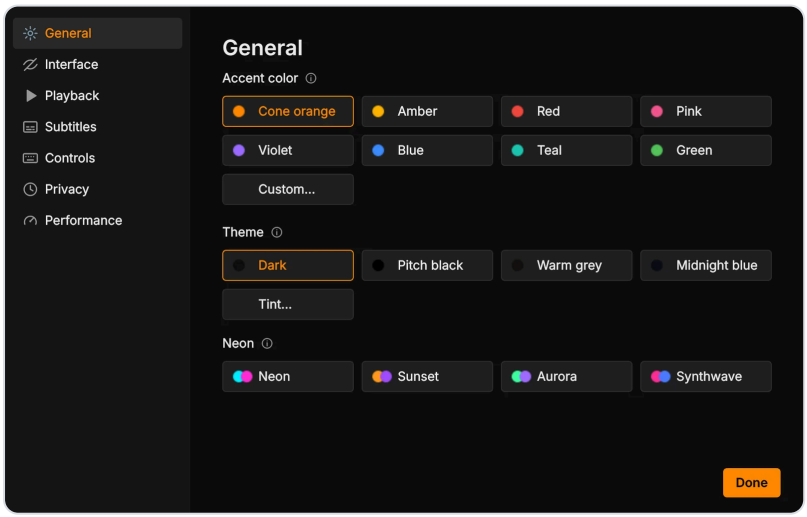
Bookmarks tab

Press `Ctrl` + `B` anywhere to bookmark the current moment. Bookmarks show as small triangles on the seek bar. In this tab, click one to jump to it and double-click to rename it. If the file has chapters, they're listed below, and they show as thin lines on the seek bar.

Preferences

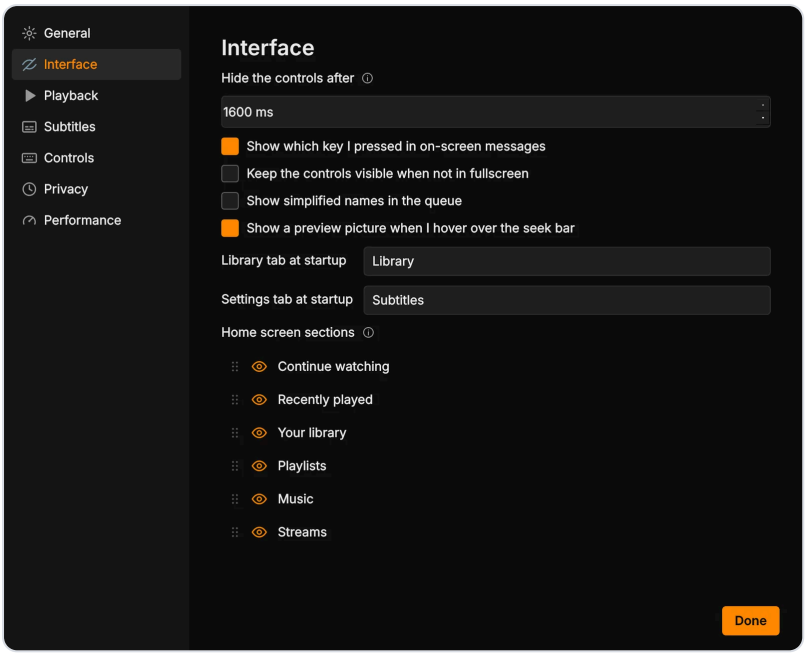
Open Preferences with `Ctrl` + `,` or **Menu > Preferences...**. Each option has an info icon; hover it for a short explanation. Changes apply straight away.

General: colours and themes



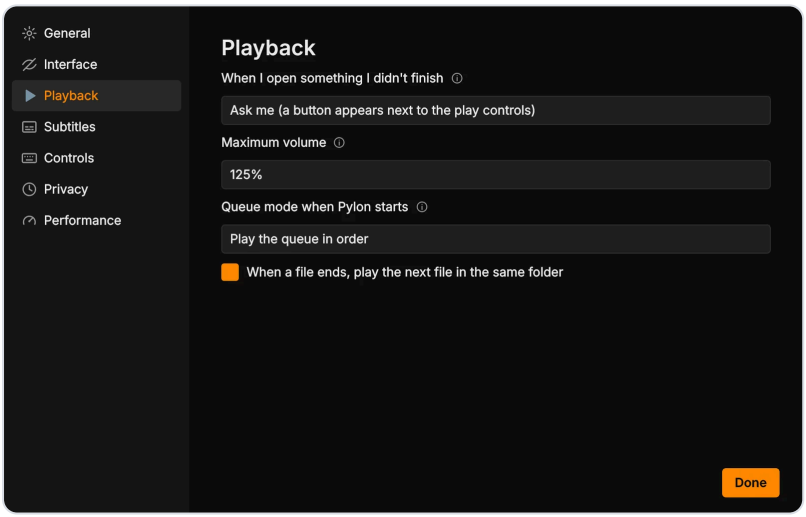
Pick an **accent color** for highlights, the seek bar and the volume, or **Custom...** for any colour. Pick a **theme**: Dark, Pitch black, Warm grey, Midnight blue, or **Tint...** for dark shades of any colour. The **Neon** themes (Neon, Sunset, Aurora, Synthwave) add glowing gradient highlights and use their own colours.

Interface



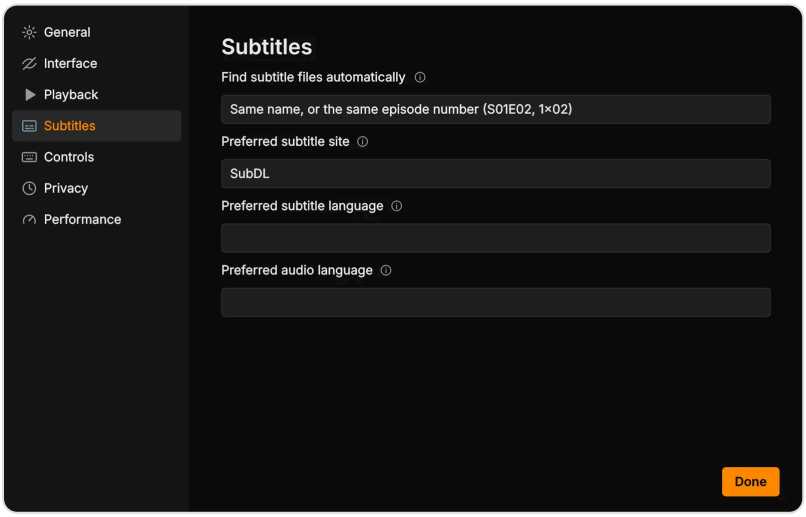
- **Hide the controls after**: how long the bars stay after the mouse stops.
- Show which key you pressed in on-screen messages, keep the controls visible in a window, show simplified names in the queue, and turn seek bar preview pictures on or off.
- **Library tab at startup** and **Settings tab at startup**: which tab each panel opens on, or the last one you used.
- **Home screen sections**: reorder and show or hide each home screen section.

Playback



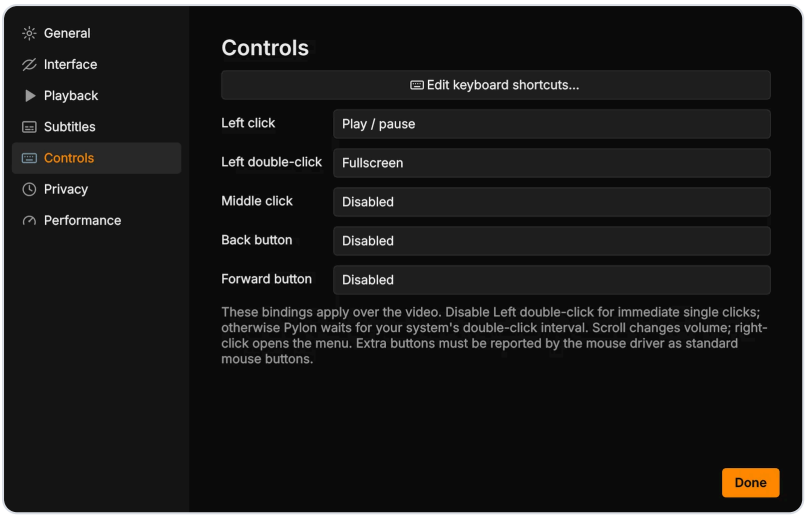
- **When I open something I didn't finish**: ask (the Continue from button), always continue, or always start from the beginning.
- **Maximum volume**: 125%, 150% or 200%. Above 100%, Pylon boosts quiet audio, like VLC. Very loud sound can distort.
- **Queue mode when Pylon starts**, and whether the next file in the folder plays when one ends.

Subtitles



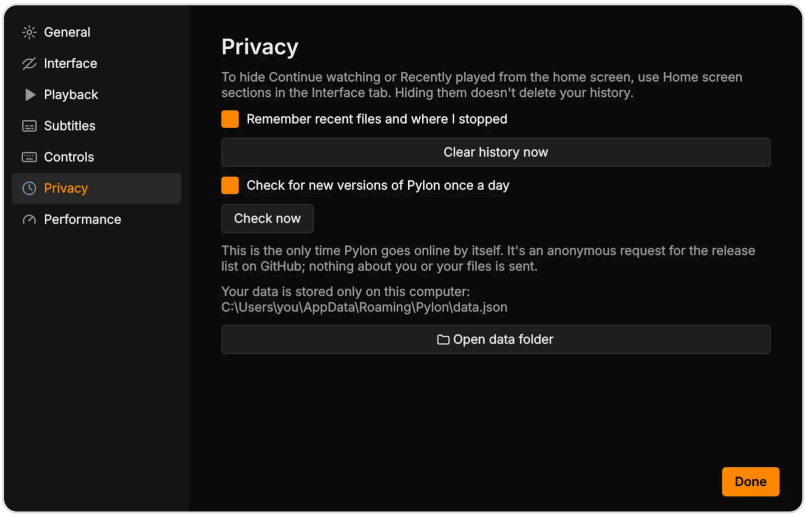
- **Find subtitle files automatically**: how closely a subtitle's name must match the video.
- **Preferred subtitle site**: marked with a star in the Find online menu. The menu always keeps the same order.
- **Preferred subtitle language** and **Preferred audio language** for every file, unless a preset says otherwise.

Controls



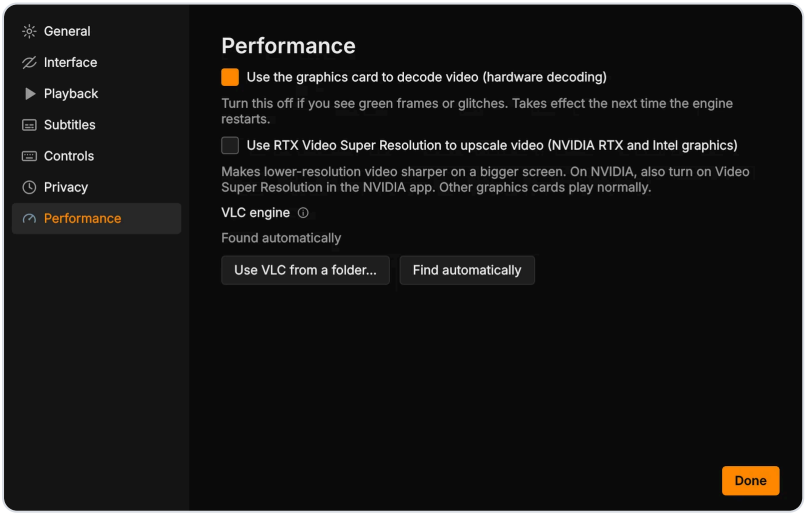
Choose what left click, left double-click, middle click and the mouse's back and forward buttons do over the video. Turn off double-click for instant single clicks. **Edit keyboard shortcuts…** opens the shortcut list.

Privacy



Turn history and resume points on or off, clear your history, and choose whether Pylon checks for new versions once a day. **Open data folder** shows where your library, history and settings are kept.

Performance



- **Hardware decoding** uses the graphics card. Turn it off if you see green frames or glitches.
- **RTX Video Super Resolution** (Windows, NVIDIA RTX and Intel graphics) makes lower-resolution video sharper on a big screen. On NVIDIA, also turn on Video Super Resolution in the NVIDIA app.
- **VLC engine**: use a VLC from a specific folder, such as a portable VLC, or let Pylon find it.

Keyboard shortcuts

Press `F1` to see every shortcut. To change one, click its key, then press the new key. `Esc` inside the box clears it, and **Reset to defaults** puts them all back.

Playing

Play / pause	`Space`
Stop	`S`
Jump forward 10s	`→`
Jump back 10s	`←`
Jump forward 1 min	`Ctrl` + `→`
Jump back 1 min	`Ctrl` + `←`
Next frame	`E`
Next in queue	`N`
Previous in queue	`P`
Faster	`]`
Slower	`[`
Normal speed	`=`

Sound and subtitles

Volume up	`↑`
Volume down	`↓`
Mute	`M`
Subtitles later (+50 ms)	`J`
Subtitles earlier (-50 ms)	`G`
Audio later (+50 ms)	`K`
Audio earlier (-50 ms)	`Shift` + `K`
Next subtitle track	`V`
Next audio track	`B`

Window and panels

Fullscreen	`F`
Fullscreen (second key)	`Enter`
Leave fullscreen	`Esc`
Picture in picture	`Ctrl` + `P`
Hide the interface	`H`
Show or hide library panel	`Ctrl` + `L`
Show or hide settings panel	`Ctrl` + `T`
Show queue	`Ctrl` + `Q`
Show or hide both side panels	`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `L`
Zoom in	`Ctrl` + `=`
Zoom out	`Ctrl` + `-`
Reset zoom	`Ctrl` + `0`

Files and other

Open file	`Ctrl` + `O`
Open folder	`Ctrl` + `F`
Open network stream	`Ctrl` + `N`
Add bookmark	`Ctrl` + `B`
Take a snapshot	`Shift` + `S`
Show keyboard shortcuts	`F1`
Open Preferences	`Ctrl` + `,`

How to...

Watch a series and always pick up where you left off

1. Add the series folder to your library with **Add folder to library** on the home screen.
2. Play the first episode. The rest of the folder goes into the queue, and each episode plays after the last.
3. Next time, click the show under **Continue watching** on the home screen, or click **Continue from** next to the play controls.

Fix subtitles that are early or late

1. Open the settings panel (`Ctrl` + `T`) on the Subtitles tab.
2. Pause just as someone starts speaking.
3. Drag the timeline until their line sits under the white playhead, or press `G` or `J`.
4. Save a preset so every episode of the show uses the same timing.

Make every episode of a show look and sound the same

1. Set the subtitle look and timing, audio and subtitle language, speed and picture for one episode.
2. In the settings panel, click the save button next to **Preset** and name it.
3. Every file in that folder now uses the preset automatically.

Watch an IPTV channel list

1. To keep it: open the library's **Streams** tab and click **Import list...**, or drop the `.m3u` file onto the list.
2. For a list online, click **Open a stream...**, paste the link and tick **Save it to Streams in the library**. Its channel count appears once it has been opened.
3. Double-click the list to load the channels into the queue, then type in the queue's search box to find a channel.
4. Right-click your favourite channels' lists and choose **Pin to top**.

Make quiet audio louder

1. Open **Preferences > Playback** and set **Maximum volume** to 150% or 200%.
2. Drag the volume, scroll over the video or press `Up` to go past 100%.

Fall asleep to a film

1. Open the settings panel on the **Playback** tab.
2. Under **Sleep timer**, choose a time, or **End of file**.

Watch in a small window while you work

1. Press `Ctrl` + `P` .
2. Drag the window anywhere and resize it from its edges. It stays on top of other apps.
3. Press `Esc` to go back.

Change the colours

1. Open **Preferences > General**.
2. Pick an accent color and a theme. Try a neon theme for glowing highlights.

Your data and updates

Pylon keeps your library, history, resume points, presets, bookmarks and subtitle pairings in one file on your computer: `%APPDATA%\Pylon` on Windows, `~/.local/share/pylon` on Linux and `~/Library/Application Support/Pylon` on macOS. Nothing is uploaded.

The only time Pylon goes online by itself is a once-a-day check for new versions: an anonymous request to GitHub for the list of Pylon releases. When there's a new version, **Menu > Update to Pylon…** appears. On Windows, **Update now** downloads and runs the installer, keeping your settings; on Linux and macOS it opens the download page. Turn the check off in **Preferences > Privacy**.

Troubleshooting

Pylon says it can't find VLC

Install VLC 3 (64-bit on Windows). For a portable VLC, click **Locate VLC folder…** in the message, or use **Preferences > Performance > Use VLC from a folder…**. On Linux, use VLC from your distribution, not the Flatpak or Snap version.

Green frames, glitches or a black picture

Turn off **hardware decoding** in **Preferences > Performance**. If you use RTX Video Super Resolution and the picture goes black after opening a panel, turn that option off and tell us on GitHub.

No sound, or Pylon closes at start on Linux

Pylon uses VLC's PulseAudio output, which PipeWire also serves. To try another output, start Pylon with `PYLON_VLC_ARGS=--aout=pipewire` (or `alsa`).

Subtitles aren't found automatically

Put them next to the video, or in a `Subs` or `Subtitles` folder, with the same name or episode number. Or use **Add subtitles…** and fix the pairing by hand. **Preferences > Subtitles** sets how closely names must match.

The subtitle look or rotation restarted the video

That's expected: VLC reads those settings when its engine starts, so Pylon restarts the video at the same spot.

Reporting a problem

Open an issue on GitHub with what you did and what happened. Attach Pylon's `error.log` and `vlc.log` from its `logs` folder (check them first: they contain file names). On Windows, `diag.bat` in the Pylon folder writes a diagnostic file too.